

Wartime Fighters

Fighters were built in huge numbers in World War II. Tens of thousands of the most successful types were built, including almost 34,000 Bf 109s. Nations and lives depended on constant development, and Germany, Britain, the USA, Japan, and the Soviet Union all built aircraft that excelled in their own ways. Some were so good that they continued in service with smaller nations as late as the 1980s.



△ Messerschmitt Bf 110G 1943

Origin Germany

Engine 2 x 1,085/1,455 hp Daimler-Benz DB 601/605 liquid-cooled inverted V12

Top speed 348 mph (560 km/h)

In production ahead of WWII, this twin-engine fighter-bomber was effective in early engagements but lacked agility, changing to ground support and night-fighting with radar, at which it excelled.



▽ Messerschmitt Bf 109G 1942

Origin Germany

Engine 1,455 hp Daimler-Benz DB 605A-1 supercharged liquid-cooled inverted V12

Top speed 386 mph (621 km/h)

The Bf, or Me109, was progressively developed throughout WWII, becoming the most-produced fighter aircraft in history, with 33,984 built. Very successful, it remained in service in Spain until 1965.



▷ Fiat CR.42 Falco 1940

Origin Italy

Engine 840 hp Fiat A.74 RC38 supercharged air-cooled 14-cylinder radial

Top speed 274 mph (441 km/h)

The ultimate biplane fighter, the "Falco" (Falcon) was the most-produced Italian fighter of WWII, with 1,818 built. Against monoplanes, it made up in agility what it lacked in speed.



▽ Lockheed P-38 Lightning 1941

Origin USA

Engine 2 x 1,725 hp Allison V-1710-111/113 turbo-supercharged liquid-cooled V12

Top speed 420 mph (676 km/h)

This distinctive, twin-boom, long-range, high-altitude interceptor fighter-bomber was fast and forgiving, but not very agile. It was in production throughout the US involvement in WWII; 10,037 were built.



△ Hawker Hurricane Mk IIB 1942

Origin UK

Engine 1,185 hp Rolls-Royce Merlin XX supercharged liquid-cooled V12

Top speed 340 mph (547 km/h)

Simpler, cheaper, and easier to build and repair than Spitfires, Hurricanes were turned out in large numbers (14,533 total) across several variants. This Mk IIB could carry two 500 lb (227 kg) bombs.



◁ Mitsubishi A6M5 Zero 1943

Origin Japan

Engine 940-1,130 hp Nakajima Sakae 12/21 supercharged air-cooled 14-cylinder radial

Top speed 340 mph (547 km/h)

This was Japan's most plentiful fighter with 10,939 built. The Zero was the most capable carrier-based fighter of its day, with excellent agility and range; not until 1943 did Allied aircraft overhaul it.

